began to prod the British at the behest of Chiang Kai-shek to recognize Chinese suzerainty over Tibet. Unable to stand up to US pressure, in the Eden Memorandum of August 1943, the British gave in but threw in a face-saving caveat—that Tibet was to be regarded as ‘autonomous’. What the Chinese understood of that word, the world will probably never know.

The organization of Assam Rifles units changed during World War II, bringing them more in line with the regular battalions of the Indian Army. After a gap of ten years, 5 Assam Rifles was re-raised on 1 April 1942. During the war it had served as a training battalion, but was also expected to look after NEFT. There was also a much-required increase in the officer strength. Prior to 1882, the entire leadership had been in the hands of police officers. Subsequently, apart from the commandant and one British sergeant (who were both deputed from the army), each battalion relied on Indian officers who by and large proved to be extremely efficient and resourceful. At the time of Independence, Indian officers, who were on deputation from the army, were running all six existing Assam Rifles units.

In November 1943, 2 Assam Rifles and some platoons of 5 Assam Rifles were removed from the Burma front and were once again placed under the command of the Inspector General of Police, Government of Assam. The main reason for the reversion of the two battalions to the state authorities at the height of World War II was an important step that would have repercussions later.

Though the administration had set up an Assam Rifles post at Rupa in 1941, the presence of a small detachment was meant to protect the Sherdukpens from their more warlike Aka and Miji neighbours. The detachment was not meant to get into a confrontation with Tibetan officials. The intrusion by the Tibetan Army in November 1942 into the Dirang Dzong area and the Kameng River Valley took the British completely by surprise. The show of strength on the part of the Tibetans was in all probability in response to Captain Lightfoot’s earlier thrust into the Tawang salient. The intrusions rattled the British who were used to bullying the Tibetans but were not prepared for any counter aggression. However, with the Japanese sweeping across Burma into Manipur and Nagaland and threatening the Assam Valley itself, the British decided not to react as the last thing they needed then was to open up another front.

The Assam Rifles post at Rupa reported the arrival of Tibetan troops and monitored their presence as they advanced right up to Bhalukpong in